Abhijit Banerjee, Esther Duflo and others have emphasized the importance of ‘randomized control trials’ in learning about economics. We see this as being a key part of the economic policy toolkit, in the process of iterative refinement.

Example 19: Bans on plastic packaging materials

There is a global problem with the use of plastic in packaging. This plastic is creating litter in the natural environment, particularly in places where the handling of solid waste is weak. Plastics are not biodegradable and the residue will linger for 500 years.

As a consequence, in 2018, single-use plastics were banned in Mumbai. [3] This is a big disruption for the packaged foods industry, which has come to value the impermeability of plastic as a tool for avoiding bacterial and insect infestations in food.

It would perhaps have made sense for the government to start by experimenting with these bans in small towns, and simultaneously establish a data-gathering and research process to measure the impacts. Perhaps the scaling up could be from a few towns to a district to a group of districts. At each step, evidence is required before making the next move. The packaging industry would also have time to develop and scale up plastic-free alternatives.

Policy reversibility

> *Do things that you can undo.*
>
> James C. Scott

In the US, one in twenty-five people who were sentenced to death were, in fact, innocent. [4] The prosecution claimed, and the judiciary agreed, that these persons were guilty of heinous crimes, beyond all reasonable doubt.